

BRICK BOOK

How to open and use the app — Desktop & Android

Brick Book is an offline-first expense tracker for the house-building project. It runs entirely in your browser — there is nothing to install on a desktop, and on a phone it can be added to your home screen like a regular app. All of your data lives on your own device; nothing is sent anywhere.

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1. Before you start

Brick Book lives at one web address (URL). This guide uses a placeholder — replace it with your app's real address once it's deployed:

```
https://your-house-ledger.vercel.app
```

Where to get the real URL: whoever set up the app deploys it once (for example, to Vercel) and that step produces this address. Ask them for it, or check the project's README for the exact deploy steps if you're setting it up yourself. Once you have it, every step below is the same — just swap in your real address.

You do not need to install any software to use Brick Book on a desktop computer — it opens in your normal web browser (Chrome, Edge, or Safari). On Android, you'll install it as an app icon in a couple of taps, covered in Section 3.

2. Opening the app on your desktop

Works in Chrome, Edge, or Safari on Windows, Mac, or Linux.

- 1 Open your web browser.
- 2 Type the app's address into the address bar: **https://your-house-ledger.vercel.app** and press Enter.
- 3 Wait a few seconds for the page to load fully the first time — this also quietly saves a copy of the app on your computer so it can open instantly (and even offline) the next time.
- 4 You'll see the dark navy **BRICK BOOK** header and the Dashboard. You're in.

Optional: pin it as its own desktop app

Chrome and Edge can install Brick Book as a standalone app window (no address bar, its own icon), the same way it works on a phone:

- 1 Look at the right side of the address bar for a small install icon (a monitor with a downward arrow, or a + in a box).
- 2 Click it, then click **Install** in the popup.
- 3 Brick Book now opens from your Desktop, Start Menu, or Dock like any other application.

If you don't see the install icon, you can skip this — a regular browser tab works exactly the same way and keeps the same data.

3. Installing the app on your Android phone

This must be done in the **Chrome** app (not Samsung Internet or another browser) for the install prompt to appear correctly.

- 1** Open the **Chrome** app on your phone.
- 2** Tap the address bar at the top and type: **https://your-house-ledger.vercel.app**, then tap Go.
- 3** Wait for the page to fully load. Keep the screen open for a few seconds — this lets the app save itself for offline use.
- 4** Tap the menu button — **three vertical dots** in the top-right corner.
- 5** Tap **Add to Home screen** (on some phones this appears as an **Install app** banner near the address bar instead — tap that if you see it).
- 6** Confirm by tapping **Add** or **Install** on the popup.
- 7** Go to your phone's home screen. You'll see a new **Brick Book** icon (dark navy square with a stacked-coins symbol).
- 8** Tap the icon to open it. The app fills the whole screen — no browser address bar or tabs — exactly like a normal installed app.

From now on, always open the app from this home screen icon, not by typing the address into Chrome again — the icon is faster and works offline immediately.

Everything in the app works with no internet connection at all — adding entries, viewing the dashboard, adding bills, and backing up or restoring your data. You can safely use it in airplane mode.

4. Dashboard — your running total

This is the screen you land on when you open the app. It updates instantly every time you add, edit, or delete anything.

- The large bold number at the top is the **total spent** across every entry in the ledger.
- Below it, a bar for each of the 11 categories (Sharik, Nitin, Wood, Electrical, Govt Fee/Chalan, MDA/Mutation, Gift, Site Prep, Legal, Utility Bill, Misc) shows how much has gone to each.
- At the bottom, a list shows how much each family member has personally paid so far.

There's nothing to tap here to change data — this screen is read-only. Use the tabs at the bottom of the screen to add or edit entries.

5. + Entry — adding an expense

Tap the **+ Entry** tab at the bottom to log a new payment. Fill in the fields:

- 1 Date** — defaults to today; tap it to pick a different date.
- 2 Category** — choose the closest fit from the dropdown (e.g. "Sharik" for a payment to that contractor).
- 3 Description** — a short label, e.g. "Payment to Sharik". Required.
- 4 Sub-vendor / detail** — optional; a shop or sub-contractor name, e.g. "Kisan Treders".
- 5 Amount (■)** — the rupee amount. Required, and must be more than zero.
- 6 Payment mode** — Cash, one of the GPay accounts, Cheque, etc.
- 7 Paid by** — which family member made the payment.
- 8 Notes** — optional, anything else worth remembering.
- 9** Tap the crimson **Save entry** button.

If the description is empty or the amount is zero, the app shows an error message under the form and won't save until it's fixed — this prevents accidental blank or ■0 entries from polluting the ledger.

After saving, a small "✓ Entry saved" confirmation appears and the form clears, ready for the next entry.

6. Ledger — searching and managing entries

Tap the **Ledger** tab to see every entry ever recorded, newest first.

- **Search box** — type any word from the description, vendor, notes, payer, or payment mode to filter the list instantly.
- **Category dropdown** (next to search) — narrow the list to one category at a time.
- Each row shows the description, date, a small category badge, payment mode, who paid, and the amount.
- The total shown just above the list reflects only the entries currently visible (i.e. after your search/filter) — handy for adding up a specific category or vendor.

Deleting an entry

- 1 Tap the small **delete** link under an entry's amount.
- 2 Two buttons appear: **Delete** (confirms) and **Keep** (cancels). This two-tap confirmation prevents accidental deletion.
- 3 Tap **Delete** to remove it permanently, or **Keep** to back out.

Exporting to CSV

Tap **Backup CSV** above the list to download a spreadsheet file of exactly what's currently visible (respecting your search/filter). Useful for opening in Excel or sharing a specific category's spend.

7. BOQ — scanning and tracking itemized bills

BOQ ("Bill of Quantities") is for recording the individual line items on a shop or contractor invoice — separate from the simple one-line ledger entries in Section 5.

Scanning a bill with the camera

The scanner reads the photo **on your phone itself** — free, no internet needed, and the photo never leaves the device.

- 1 Tap the **BOQ** tab, then tap **Scan bill** (or **Upload photo** for a picture already in your gallery).
- 2 Photograph the bill: good light, bill flat, fill the frame, hold steady.
- 3 Wait while it reads — a progress line shows e.g. "Reading the bill on this phone... 60%". The first scan takes the longest.
- 4 A review screen opens with the vendor, invoice number, date, category (guessed from the products — paint words file it under Paint, pipes under Plumbing, and so on) and the line items it could read.

- 5 **Check every row against the paper bill.** The reader makes mistakes, especially with numbers — tap any cell to correct it, use **+ add row** for lines it missed, and the **×** button to remove junk rows.
- 6 Confirm the green "lines sum ✓ match" check against the printed total, then tap **Save bill**.

Leave "Add the material rows to Stock" ticked (it is on by default) and every product with a quantity also lands in the Stock tab as received inventory — see Section 8.

Scanning a handwritten size list (timber, marble)

A timber or marble dealer usually hands over a rough handwritten slip instead of a printed bill, and prices it by **size** rather than by quantity — a heading like "Teak", then lines reading **8¼ x 9 x 8 - III**, then a total and a rate. The ordinary scanner cannot read that: there is no invoice number, no quantity column, and the amount is worked out from the measurements. Use **Size list** for these.

- 1 Tap the **BOQ** tab, then tap **Size list** and photograph the slip.
- 2 Each size becomes one row: **length in feet**, **width in inches**, **thickness in inches**, and how many **pieces** of that size. The tally marks after the dash (I, II, III) are the piece count.
- 3 The app works out the cubic feet for each row itself (length × width × thickness ÷ 144 × pieces) and adds them up.
- 4 Check the **quantity panel**: it shows what the sizes measure next to the total the dealer wrote. If the two agree it turns green. If they differ it turns red and will not save until you have either fixed a size or ticked to accept the difference.
- 5 Each row shows the line as written on the slip underneath it, so you can check a size against the photo without re-reading the whole paper.

*Reading handwriting needs an internet connection — unlike a printed bill, there is no on-device fallback for it. The **Handwritten slip** checkbox is ticked automatically; it tells the app not to demand an invoice number the paper never had.*

Typing a bill manually

- 1 Tap the **BOQ** tab, then tap **Type manually**.
- 2 Fill in **Vendor**, **Invoice #**, **Date**, and **Category**.
- 3 Enter the **Invoice total** — the grand total printed on the physical bill.
- 4 For each line on the bill, add a row: description, quantity, unit, rate, and amount. Tap **+ add row** for more lines (e.g. separate rows for SGST, CGST, or Rounding, exactly as printed).
- 5 Check the summary line at the bottom: it shows whether your line items add up to the invoice total. If they match, it turns green with a checkmark. If not, it turns red and shows the difference.
- 6 If there's a genuine mismatch you can't resolve, tick the acknowledgement checkbox that appears to save anyway.

- 7 Only tick "**Also create a ledger entry for this bill's total**" if this payment *isn't* already recorded in the Ledger — otherwise you'll double-count it.
- 8 Tap **Save bill**.

Reconciliation table

Below the Add Bill button, a table compares, per category, how much you've itemized in BOQ bills versus how much is recorded in the Ledger — a quick sanity check on whether your itemized bills line up with your actual payments.

Viewing and deleting bills

- 1 Under **Bills on record**, tap any bill to expand it and see every line item.
- 2 Tap **delete this bill**, then confirm, to remove the whole bill (all its line items) at once.

8. Stock — inventory given to labour vs. left with you

The **Stock** tab tracks every material — how much came in from bills, how much you handed to the labour, and how much is still with you. Items arrive here automatically when you save a scanned bill (Section 7), or you can add them by hand.

Reading an item card

- The big green number on the right is the **balance left with you** (it turns red if more went out than came in — a sign something wasn't recorded).
- Below the name: "in 20 · out 8" — total received vs. total given out.
- The **checkbox** on the left is for marking a material as finished / fully settled: tick it and the card greys out and drops to the bottom of the list, so the open items stay on top.
- Category chips at the top (Paint, Plumbing, Tiles, Marble, Wood, Aluminium, ...) filter the list to one kind of material.

Recording a hand-over to labour

- 1 Find the material's card (use the category chips to narrow down).
- 2 Tap – **Given out**.
- 3 Enter the quantity and, optionally, who took it (e.g. "painter Ramesh").
- 4 Tap **Save** — the balance updates instantly, and the hand-over is recorded with today's date.

*Use + **Received** the same way when material arrives without a scanned bill. Tap **History** on any card to see every dated movement; a wrong one can be deleted with its × button.*

Adding an item by hand

- 1 Tap + **Add item** at the top of the Stock tab.
- 2 Enter the material name (e.g. "Apex Ultima White 20L"), pick its category, and give the unit you count it in (L, pcs, kg, bags...).
- 3 Tap **Add to stock list**, then record quantities with + **Received** / – **Given out**.

The Dashboard also shows a compact "Stock in hand" list of open materials with their balances, so you see at a glance what's on site.

9. Data — importing your old list, backup, restore & reset

Tap the **Data** tab. This is your safety net — since everything lives only on this device, exporting a backup is the only way to protect against a lost or reset phone.

Bringing in expenses you already recorded elsewhere

If you have been keeping this house's spending in a phone note, a WhatsApp message to yourself, or an Excel sheet, you do not have to type it all in again. Tap **Import a list or spreadsheet** at the top of the Data tab. This **adds** to what you already have — it never replaces it, and nothing is saved until you have looked at every row.

From a spreadsheet (.xlsx or .csv):

- 1 Choose the file. If the workbook has several sheets, pick the right one.
- 2 The app shows each column with a sample of what is in it and its best guess at what it holds — Date, Description, Amount, and so on. Correct anything it got wrong.
- 3 Tap **Check rows**, look through the list, and tap **Import**.

*A spreadsheet read this way is handled **entirely on your phone**. Nothing is uploaded and it works with no signal.*

From a note or a message:

- 1 Paste the list into the box — lines like "12/3 cement 4500 cash" are fine, in English, Hindi or a mix.
- 2 Tap **Read this list**. Because this text has no columns to follow, it has to be read by the AI reader, which means sending it off the phone. The app tells you exactly how much is about to be sent and asks first; you can say no and map a spreadsheet instead.
- 3 Check every row — especially the amounts — then tap **Import**.

*Rows that look like something already in your ledger (same date, same amount, similar description) come in **unticked** and are marked in red, so importing the same list twice will not double your totals. Every imported entry is tagged "Imported from ..." in its notes, so you can always find them again.*

Once your old list is in, you are done with importing — add each expense as it happens from then on, and nothing needs to be read by AI again.

Exporting a backup

- 1 Tap **Export full backup (.json)**.
- 2 A file downloads to your device containing every ledger entry and BOQ item.
- 3 Move or copy that file somewhere safe — email it to yourself, save it to Google Drive, etc. Do this regularly.

The "Last backup" date at the top of this screen turns red if it's been more than 7 days, or if you've never backed up — treat that as a reminder, not just decoration.

Restoring from a backup

- 1 Tap **Import / restore from backup...** and choose a previously exported **.json** file.
- 2 The app shows how many entries and BOQ items are in that file and warns that this will **replace** everything currently on the device.
- 3 Confirm to proceed, or cancel to back out without changing anything.

Other options on this screen

- **Entries CSV / BOQ CSV** — export either table separately as a spreadsheet.
- **Reset to seed data** — wipes everything and restores the original starting data. Requires confirming twice, since it can't be undone unless you've exported a backup first. Mainly useful while testing.

10. Good habits & troubleshooting

- **Back up weekly at minimum.** The app keeps data only on the one device you're using — there's no cloud sync.
- **Always launch from the home-screen icon** on your phone, not by retyping the address in Chrome.
- **Airplane mode is fine.** Every screen — Dashboard, + Entry, Ledger, BOQ, and Data — works with no signal at all.
- **Android back button** takes you back to the Dashboard from any tab, and closes a bill's review screen, without ever closing the app itself.
- **If the app looks out of date after an update** was made to it, close it fully and reopen from the home screen icon — it fetches the newest version automatically the next time it's online.
- **If install doesn't appear** on Android, make sure you're using the Chrome app (not another browser), and that the page has fully finished loading before opening the three-dot menu.